

Mamenchisaurus hochuanensis (ma-men-chi-sawr-us)

Meaning: Mamenchi is the locality in the People's Republic of China where this kind of dinosaur was first found.

Age: Late Jurassic (140-155 m.yrs.)

Diet: Plant-eater

Size: 22 metres long

"Dragon bones" have been long used in China as cures for a multitude of ills, and when found in times past they were often ground up for sale in Chinese drug stores. Often it was the bones and teeth of extinct backboneed animals that were used and palaeontologists have often been led to rich fossil sites by following up the origin of drug store specimens.

From one "dragon bone" site came the skeleton of *Mamenchisaurus hochuanensis*, on display in the exhibition. The bones of this dinosaur were discovered in 1957 by a petroleum exploration team working near Kuanmushan in Hochuan County of Sichuan Province, western China. The Sichuan Provincial Museum staff then spent the next few months excavating a nearly complete skeleton from the 150 million year old Jurassic red shales and claystones that were themselves probably the "fossil remains" of a once broad flood plain. Eventually the bones were moved to the Institute of Vertebrate Paleontology and Paleoanthropology in Beijing where a team of preparators meticulously removed the hard concretionary rock that surrounded most of the bones and preserved the skeleton for scientific study.

Mamenchisaurus was first described in detail by two scientists in 1972, Dr. C. C. Young, the father of vertebrate palaeontology in China, and S. C. Zhao. It was found to be a new kind of sauropod dinosaur with enormous dimensions: 22 metres in length, 3.5 metres high at the shoulder, with a probable weight of 40-50 tonnes. The plant eating sauropods all have a very similar body shape and are known from all continents except Antarctica.

Mamenchisaurus, however, was just a little different from other sauropods in that it had an unusually long neck, in part because it had increased the number of vertebrae. There were other differences too — in the shapes of the vertebrae, pelvis, and ribs.

Scientifically *Mamenchisaurus* is important because it is so complete. It shows the detailed anatomy and proportions of this ancient, extinct beast. But beyond that it is awe inspiring to layman and scientist alike in its sheer size and its architectural beauty.

